

honest—labor unions have helped raise the living standards not only of the American worker, but of every American citizen. The gains organized labor has won at the bargaining table have, by raising the workers' buying power, contributed materially to the country's growth. The myth that labor is out to wreck the free-enterprise system has been lovingly nurtured in certain quarters. I, for one, could not disagree more. I cannot see that free, honest American unions pose any threat to American capitalism. If anything, they are among democracy's strongest bulwarks against political or economic totalitarianism.

I've observed that most American workers are well aware that they are enjoying benefits and a living standard they could never find in any other country or under any other political or economic system. The majority of U.S.

labor leaders are cognizant of the grim alternatives to the free-enterprise system and they have no taste for them, be they alternatives offered by the extreme left or right.

The fact that our economy is thriving—that our gross national product now exceeds *half a trillion dollars*

*annually*—would seem sufficient to refute any charge that labor is wrecking or seeking to wreck that economy.

Even more convincing proof is provided by yet another fact often ignored or conveniently forgotten by chronic union haters: our free-enterprise economy has burgeoned during the very period that labor unions gained their greatest strength.

"Our members may clamor for higher wages, shorter hours and fringe benefits," a prominent labor leader told me. "But neither they nor union officials want to destroy or even change the American free-enterprise system. Labor